

“THE ETERNAL MYSTERY OF THE WORLD IS ITS COMPREHENSIBILITY.”

Albert Einstein, in the *Franklin Institute Journal*, March 1936

German-born Albert Einstein became one of the world's most famous scientists after the development of his Special Theory of Relativity.

IN RUSSIA, DISCONTENT WITH THE CZAR, NICHOLAS II, had been growing, and there were calls for a constitutional monarchy. This was compounded by the humiliating defeat in the Russo-Japanese War (see 1904). **Protests** spread around the country. In February, Nicholas promised to set up an **elected assembly**, but this did nothing to stop the unrest. Finally, the military joined in, and June saw a mutiny by the crew of the **battleship Potemkin**. By October, Nicholas promised a constitution and an elected legislature, but this was insufficient for the protesters, who organized themselves into **soviets** (revolutionary councils). One of the leaders, **Leon Trotsky** (1879–1940), was jailed. Although the protests continued, anti-revolutionary forces finally suppressed what became known as the **Russian Revolution of 1905**. The following year, Nicholas implemented reforms, the **Fundamental Laws**, which included the creation of an elected legislature, or **Duma**.

In **Switzerland**, the German physicist **Albert Einstein** (1879–1955) had received his doctorate and international acclaim for his publications. The most influential was known as the **Special Theory of Relativity**, which explained the relationship between mass and energy in the

equation $E=mc^2$. In 1921 he would receive a Nobel Prize for his scientific contributions.

In **India**, the British viceroy Lord Curzon (1859–1925) was facing increased nationalist opposition. He decided to **partition** the

province of **Bengal**, joining East Bengal and Assam, with a capital in Dhaka. This move was attacked as an attempt to stifle the **nationalist movement**, which had strong support throughout Bengal.



Film poster

The film *Battleship Potemkin* (1925), made by the Russian director Sergei Eisenstein, dramatized the 1905 mutiny of the ship's crew.



The ruins of the San Francisco City Hall after the 1906 earthquake.

SAN FRANCISCO EARTHQUAKE

25,000 BUILDINGS DESTROYED
450–700 PEOPLE DIED
\$350 MILLION OF DAMAGE

SITUATED ON ONE OF THE WORLD'S MOST ACTIVE FAULT LINES—the San Andreas, which runs for 810 miles (1,300 km)—the city of **San Francisco** is susceptible to **earthquakes**. By 1906, people in the growing city were used to the earth moving—there had been recorded quakes in 1836, 1865, 1868, and 1892—but nothing had been done to make the city of 400,000 people better prepared. On April 18, San Francisco bore the brunt of what was later estimated to be a **7.8 magnitude earthquake**, while people as far afield as Los Angeles and Nevada also felt shaking. The quake lasted less than a minute, but it **wreaked damage** that would take years to repair, as buildings collapsed and many caught fire throughout the city.

In India, the **All India Muslim League** was established—initially with the support of the British government—with the aim of protecting the rights of Muslims. Some 3,000 delegates attended its first meeting on December 30. By 1913 it had joined the growing call for **self-rule in India**.



Life for Romanian peasants was harsh and many wanted land reform.

PEASANT UNREST THAT HAD BEEN SPREADING throughout the countryside in **Romania** culminated in a **revolt** in 1907. This was fueled by land issues, as the peasants were forced into **exploitative contracts**, meaning many farmers had to live in poverty. As the rioting spread through villages, up to **10,000 people were killed** before it was suppressed by the military.

In Southeast Asia, **Cambodia** had clawed back some of its western provinces from Thailand due to **French pressure**. By 1863, France had established a strong presence in Cambodia, eventually restricting the Cambodian king's powers and installing a governor. This paved the way for **colonization** by the French, but angered Cambodian nationalists. The resistance was quelled by 1907.



The French in Thailand

A 19th-century French gunboat, armed with a Hotchkiss Cannon, patrols the waters of the Chao Phraya River in Bangkok, Thailand.

January 22 Bloody Sunday massacre of 500 Russian demonstrators at the Winter Palace, St Petersburg

March 31 Start of the First Moroccan Crisis in which Germany challenges France's dominance in Morocco

May 15 Las Vegas founded in the US

April 4 Earthquake in Kangara, India, kills 20,000

May 27 The Japanese fleet destroys the Russian fleet at the **Battle of Tsushima** in the Russo-Japanese War

June 30 Special Theory of Relativity published by German physicist **Albert Einstein** (1879–1955)

June 7 Norway gains independence

October 16 Partition of Bengal and nationalist agitation in India

April 18 Great San Francisco earthquake almost destroys the city

August 23 US troops appear in Cuba at request of ousted president

December 30 Foundation of All India Muslim League

March Peasant revolt in Romania against feudal laws

March 15 Nineteen women elected to Finnish parliament

July 25 Korea becomes a protectorate of Japan

August 31 Creation of Triple Entente, an alliance between Britain, France, and Russia